

GOD'S PROMISES

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PART ONE

"I will be a Father unto you, and ye shall be my sons and daughters" (2 Corinthians 6:18).

(All scriptures are from the King James Version unless specified otherwise)

It is the time for the church, the body of Christ, to believe that the Lord is faithful to fulfill the promises of His Word. It is not business as usual, where we walk merely hoping that God will fulfill His promises to us. Yes, we can and have and should pray unceasingly. However, are we ready to stand on His promises and have complete faith believing in Him and His Word?

"For my thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways my ways, saith the LORD. For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways, and my thoughts than your thoughts. For as the rain cometh down, and the snow from heaven, and returneth not thither; but watereth the earth, and maketh it bring forth and bud, that it may give seed to the sower; and bread to the eater: So shall my word be that goeth forth out of my mouth: it shall not return unto me void, but it shall accomplish that which I please, and it shall prosper in the thing whereto I sent it" (Isaiah 55:8-11).

When the Lord puts forth His Word, there is a purpose for it, and there will be a fulfillment of it. God's Word will be fulfilled because it will not return unto Him void. The challenge we have is that when His Word is not fulfilled within our desired timeline, our minds begin to be filled with fear and doubt.

I would like to premise your reading by highlighting specific focus points that will be emphasized throughout this article.

God's Promises: It is hoped that by highlighting the promises contained within the presented scriptures, it will inspire your reading of the Word to recognize the abundance of His promises to us.

God's Faithful Fulfillment Of His Promises: God has demonstrated

repeatedly, both in the Scriptures and in each of our lives, His faithfulness to fulfill His promises.

I Will Be Their God And They Will Be My People: This specific promise, in one form or another, is found throughout the Scriptures. The fulfillment of this promise will change the words "will be" to "am" and "are." *I am God their Father, and they are my sons and daughters.*

Man's Responsibility: God made mankind elemental to His plan. As such, mankind has a role within His plan. God's plan was established before the foundations of the world.

"And God said, Let us make man in our image, after our likeness: and let them have dominion (prevail against, reign, bear rule) over the fish of the sea, and over the fowl of the air, and over the cattle, and over all the earth, and over every creeping thing that creepeth upon the earth. So God created man in his own image, in the image of God created he him; male and female created he them" (Genesis 1:26-27).

"Genesis" was a long time ago and as of yet mankind has not attained to the fulfillment of His Word. Have we entered into dominion and ruling and reigning spoken by God in this passage? No, we have not! However, that is the promised fulfillment that has been given to us through His Word.

Let us believe Paul in his admonishment to the Philippians that God is faithful to fulfill His plan and purpose. *"Being confident of this very thing, that he which hath begun a good work in you will perform it until the day of Jesus Christ"* (Philippians 1:6).

Paul speaks of God's promises to the Church in Corinth. *"For all the promises of God in him are yea, and in him Amen, unto the glory of God by us"* (2 Corinthians 1:20).

Though God has given us responsibility, the glory does not go to

us, but “by us” the glory goes to God. To enter into the fullness of sonship, the body of Christ must believe God is faithful to the fulfilling of His promises. It is not by our own strength, not by our own intellectual understanding, but with hope and by faith, believing His Word.

Paul proclaims that all things can be done through Christ. *“I can do all things through Christ which strengtheneth me”* (Philippians 4:13). Did any glory go to Paul? No! All the glory went to Christ.

God’s promises and plans will be fulfilled, from Genesis to Revelation. All His Word will be fulfilled. We, the Church, the body of Christ, must believe and come to know that every word in the Scriptures will be fulfilled by God. Why? Because that is His plan, and it will be fulfilled. In the Book of Romans, Paul confirms that man is made in the image of God and His Son. *“For whom he did foreknow, he also did predestinate to be conformed to the image of his Son, (see Genesis 1:26-27) that he (Christ) might be the firstborn among many brethren”* (Romans 8:29). This declaration will be accomplished. The glory belongs to God but will be manifested by us (see 2 Corinthians 1:20).

There is an axiom that has been repeated many times: In the Old Testament, Christ concealed, in the New Testament, Christ revealed. The Old Testament has many types that in the New Testament are fulfilled.

There will be four Old Testament types presented here. Their fulfillment in the New Testament will also be addressed later in this article.

To focus on the principles presented earlier, I would like to begin with God’s promises to Abram/Abraham. (For context, please read Genesis 17:1-8)

“And when Abram was ninety years old and nine, the LORD appeared to Abram, and said unto him, I am the Almighty God; walk before me, and be thou perfect” (Genesis 17:1). Perfect in this verse comes from the Hebrew “tāmim” (taw-meem’), meaning: complete, whole, unimpaired, having integrity.

Man’s Responsibility: Abram’s responsibility was to walk completely, with full integrity, and unimpaired before God. Theirs was to be a relationship, alike to Adam and Eve walking with God in the cool of the day in the Garden of Eden. (For context, please read Genesis 3:8.)

Currently, we walk impaired and crippled by the baggage we carry from those things with which the spirit of the world encumbers us. This walk that God called Abram to was a walk of integrity and to be without impairment—not a call to be “without spot and blemish.” The future Mosaic law would prove that we, as mankind with our carnal nature, were incapable of accomplishing this “without spot and blemish” definition of perfection in our own strength and by our thinking with our own mind.

God’s Promises: (See Genesis 17:2-8) God’s promises, translated here as a covenant, were abundant and everlasting. God would make Abram fruitful and multiply his descendants exceedingly, and give to them, as an everlasting inheritance, the land of Canaan. Most importantly, God promised He would be the God of Abram and his descendants.

I would like to continue with the promises given to Moses and the children of Israel. (For context, please read Exodus 6:1-7.) The children of Israel had been in Egypt for 400 years and had been living under severe bondage for the latter portion of this time, and they had cried unto the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob for deliverance. God

placed a calling on Moses to set God’s people free. They were God’s people through the promises given by God to Abram generations prior to Moses’ time.

God’s Faithful Fulfillment Of His Promises: *“And I have also heard the groaning of the children of Israel, whom the Egyptians keep in bondage; and I have remembered my covenant”* (Exodus 6:5). (See Genesis 17:1-8.)

As a result of Moses’ initial request to Pharaoh that he let the children of Israel go, Pharaoh instead increased their labors. God did not forget His promises to Abram, and He spoke to Abraham’s descendants through Moses.

God’s Promises: (For context, please read Exodus 6:1, 4, 6-7.) God promises that He will deliver the children of Israel from Pharaoh and Egypt with a strong hand and rid them of their burdens and bondage. He establishes His covenant with them through Abraham. He claims them as His own and that He will be to them a God and will take them as His people. Then His people will know that it was their God that delivered them. *“And I will take you to me for a people, and I will be to you a God: and ye shall know that I am the LORD your God, which bringeth you out from under the burdens of the Egyptians”* (Exodus 6:7).

Let us jump forward to Exodus chapter 19. (For context, please read Exodus 19:1-6)

God’s Faithful Fulfillment Of His Promises: *“Ye have seen what I did unto the Egyptians, and how I bare you on eagles’ wings, and brought you unto myself”* (Exodus 19:4). God proves to Israel His love as their God by delivering them from bondage in Egypt and bringing them unto Himself.

Man’s Responsibility: *“Now therefore, if ye will obey my voice indeed, and keep my covenant”* (Exodus 19:5). Israel’s responsibility was to obey His voice and keep His covenant. What covenant were they to keep? This was not the Mosaic Law, as the Law had not yet been given to Moses. So, what is God asking His people to keep? Let’s remember the covenant that was spoken to Abraham: *“walk before me, and be thou perfect”* (Genesis 17:1). How easily we can complicate what He has asked us to do and how He wants us to walk. The children of Israel were to have an intimate relationship with God—to walk completely and unimpaired before Him.

This intimate relationship and walk are personified in the life of Enoch:

“And Enoch lived sixty and five years, and begat Methuselah: And Enoch walked with God after he begat Methuselah three hundred years, and begat sons and daughters: And all the days of Enoch were three hundred sixty and five years: And Enoch walked with God: and he was not; for God took him” (Genesis 5:21-24).

This is all we know of Enoch: He walked with God such that *“God took him.”* I envision that God did not take Enoch via the grave, but rather in similar glory to that of Elijah. My local elder, many times over the years, shared a memorable anecdote regarding Enoch:

One day, as God and Enoch were fellowshiping together, God said, *“Enoch, we are closer to my home than yours; come home with me.”*

That is a walk of perfection. Unimpaired! With integrity! Are we willing to walk and live in that way? What are we holding onto? What are we reserving? What are we stockpiling?

God’s Promises: In God’s eyes, Israel would be a peculiar treasure, a kingdom of priests, a holy nation: *“Now therefore, if ye will obey my voice indeed, and keep my covenant, then ye shall be a peculiar*

treasure unto me above all people: for all the earth is mine.” (For further context, please read Psalm 24) *“And ye shall be unto me a kingdom of priests, and an holy nation”* (Exodus 19:5–6).

There were promises given to the children of Israel by God for their building—according to the pattern instructed by God—of the Tabernacle in the wilderness. God’s desire was for a more intimate dwelling place with His people. (For context, please read Exodus 29:42–46.)

God’s Promises: God promised to dwell among the children of Israel and meet with them and speak to them from the door of His sanctified abiding place. He reiterates His promise that He will be their God: *“And I will dwell among the children of Israel, and will be their God”* (Exodus 29:45).

God’s Faithful Fulfillment Of His Promises: *“And they shall know that I am the LORD their God, that brought them forth out of the land of Egypt, that I may dwell among them: I am the LORD their God”* (Exodus 29:46). God continually brings to their remembrance: Look what I have done. You should have faith in Me because I promised this, and I fulfilled it.

If you could endure for one more example: God promised the children of Israel many blessings if they walked in His righteous laws (Mosaic Law). (For context, please read Leviticus 26:1–12.)

Man’s Responsibility: *“Ye shall keep my sabbaths, and reverence my sanctuary: I am the LORD. If ye walk in my statutes, and keep my commandments, and do them”* (Leviticus 26:2–3). The children of Israel’s responsibility would be to walk obediently in the **doing** of God’s righteous laws, statutes, and commandments.

God’s Promises: For Israel’s obedience, He would bless them with an abundance of promises. God here makes the demonstrative promise and avowal: **I will be their God, and they will be My people.** *“And I will walk among you, and will be your God, and ye shall be my people”* (Leviticus 26:12). This was a promise to the children of God by God. I can describe it as nothing else. His Word, His plan, and His promises will be fulfilled and are everlasting.

After crossing the River Jordan and claiming their inheritance in the Promised Land, the children of Israel, God’s people, walked under the shepherdship of judges appointed and led by God. God was lovingly shepherding them, and they were living under the theocracy of God.

Over time, the children of Israel grew dissatisfied and unfulfilled in their earthly, nation status. They desired a king *“like all the nations”* (1 Samuel 8:5) to rule over them. Their peculiarity, their calling as priests, their holiness as a nation, their being identified as God’s people, living under God’s theocracy, was no longer the desire of their heart.

This appears to be where the rebellion of the children of Israel crossed the line. In the natural, the children of Israel had now rejected God and wanted to walk in the ways of the worldly kingdoms around them. They had abandoned God. But we know that God did not abandon the children of Israel. Why? Because of His covenant. (For context, please read Isaiah 45:18–23)

“I have sworn by myself, the word is gone out of my mouth in righteousness, and shall not return” (remember Isaiah 55:11), *“That unto me every knee shall bow, every tongue shall swear”* (Isaiah 45:23).

The author of Hebrews speaks to the covenant with Abraham, which is in confirmation of this same fact: *“For when God made promise to Abraham, because he could swear by no greater, he swore by himself, Saying, Surely blessing I will bless thee, and multiplying I*

will multiply thee. And so, after he had patiently endured, he obtained the promise” (Hebrews 6:13–15).

In Genesis chapter 15, you can read about the covenant ritual that was, according to their customs, performed by two parties to seal their covenant with each other. However, in the 17th verse you will see that God was the only party to this one-way covenant.

God continued to be the God of His people in spite of their shortcomings—in spite of them choosing a king to rule over them rather than God. God chose Saul from the tribe of Benjamin as the first king of what has historically been called the unified nation of Israel. God also chose Saul’s successor, David, who was from the tribe of Judah. Israel prospered under the rule of David. Israel continued to prosper under Solomon, who inherited his father David’s kingdom. Solomon built the Temple of God in Jerusalem.

At the end of Solomon’s reign, c. 1040 BC, the landmass occupied by the 12 tribes of Israel was at its zenith and fulfilled God’s promise to Abraham. (For further context, please read Genesis 12:7, 13:15–17, 15:7, 17:8.)

This is where Israel’s succession planning under a king began to collapse. Solomon’s son Rehoboam, who had political sway over the tribe of Judah and the tribe of Benjamin, was a poor diplomat and was in conflict with Jeroboam of the tribe of Ephraim. Jeroboam was a strong leader, having significant political influence over the remaining ten tribes of Israel. When their differences could not be resolved, the unified kingdom split into two. The ten tribes controlled by Jeroboam to the north became the Kingdom of Israel, and the two southerly tribes ruled by Rehoboam became the Kingdom of Judah.

The kingdoms of Israel and Judah are recorded in the biblical books of 1 & 2 Kings and 1 & 2 Chronicles. The Kingdom of Israel was conquered and assimilated by the Assyrians in c. 720 BC. The Kingdom of Judah was conquered by the Babylonians and the Temple in Jerusalem destroyed in c. 587 BC.

During the reign of the kings of Israel and the kings of Judah, God never forgot His promise to Abram and His love for His people. God established prophets (men of God) in both Israel and Judah to admonish His people—through prophecy (the Word of God)—about the ramifications of living their lives according to their own thoughts and their own ways. Likewise, God, through these prophets of God, reminded His people of His continuing love for them and the promises that were their inheritance.

I Will Be Their God And They Will Be My People This promise, in various forms, is recorded repeatedly throughout the Old Testament—in the Book of Hosea, the Book of Jeremiah, the Book of Ezekiel, and the Book of Zechariah. The Old Testament scriptures speak of God’s promises and workings with the descendants, through the bloodline—the DNA—of Abraham.

Israel was called to be a peculiar treasure unto God, above all people, a kingdom of priests, a holy nation. (Remember Exodus 19:1–6). As a kingdom of priests, this calling—this responsibility—that God had placed upon them was theirs to fulfill. The history of Israel in the Scriptures documents the inability of Israel, by their own understanding, by their own strength, to fulfill this calling. However, God’s plan has no accommodation for anything less than complete fulfillment.

Christ is the testator of a new and better covenant. (For context, please read Hebrews chapter 9.)

I would like to bring to our attention the fact that, in the King James Version, the phrase “Heavenly Father” is only found in the New Testament. In the Old Testament, it is God and Lord and Lord God.

Christ taught us to pray: “*Our Father which art in heaven...*” (Matthew 6:9–15). This will become relevant as we see the transitioning from *I Will Be Their God And They Will Be My People*, to the more intimate promise, *I Will Be Their Father And They Will Be My Sons And Daughters*.

God’s purpose and plan will be fulfilled through Christ. “*Think not that I (Jesus Christ) am come to destroy the law, or the prophets: I am not come to destroy, but to fulfil*” (Matthew 5:17). Christ the only begotten Son of God, was sent as one who walked perfectly before God, His Father. Similar to promises given to Abraham for him and his heirs, through belief in Jesus Christ, we will be heirs of God’s promise of eternal life.

The Old Testament foretells of the promise of the coming of Jesus Christ, God’s Son. “*For unto us a child is born, unto us a son is given: and the government shall be upon his shoulder: and his name shall be called Wonderful, Counsellor, The mighty God, The everlasting Father, The Prince of Peace.*” (Isaiah 9:6). This will be fulfilled to the glory of God. **By us!** (remember 2 Corinthians 1:20)

“*And as Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, (for context please read Numbers 21:8-9) even so must the Son of man be lifted up: That whosoever believeth in him (Christ) should not perish, but have eternal life. For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him (Christ) should not perish, but have everlasting life. For God sent not his Son into the world to condemn the world; but that the world through him (Christ) might be saved*” (John 3:14-17)

Man’s Responsibility: Believing in Christ, is the beginning of our calling, our walk.

God’s Promises: The promise of everlasting life is for those who believe Christ was sent by our Heavenly Father to save the world. If Christ is the testator of a new covenant/testament, (see Hebrews chapter 9) who is the other party? Again, this is a one-way covenant. We were not participants in this covenant but we are the inheritors of its promises. God will be faithful to fulfill His word of everlasting life. Old Testament type, God’s covenant with Abraham and his descendants. New Testament fulfillment, a new covenant through Christ.

Peter speaks of those who believe in and follow Christ.

“*But ye are a chosen generation, a royal priesthood, an holy nation, a peculiar people; that ye should shew forth the praises of him (remember 2 Corinthians 1:20) who hath called you out of darkness into his marvellous light*” (1 Peter 2:9).

Man’s Responsibility: Similar to 2 Corinthians 1:20, “*that ye should shew forth the praises of him.*”

God’s Faithful Fulfillment Of His promises: Peter declares the followers of Christ as a chosen generation, as a royal priesthood, as an holy nation, as a peculiar people—as a people called out of darkness into His (Christ’s) marvellous light. We have not yet reached the fullness of this declaration, but it will be fulfilled because God promised it. It will be fulfilled.

Old Testament type: His people *shall* be a peculiar treasure, a kingdom of priests, an holy nation. New Testament fulfillment: His people *are* a chosen generation, a royal priesthood, an holy nation, a peculiar people.

We have been promised the indwelling Comforter, the Holy Spirit, by Christ. Paul speaks of believers being the temple of the living God.

“*Be ye not unequally yoked together with unbelievers: for what fellowship hath righteousness with unrighteousness? and what communion hath light with darkness? And what concord hath Christ with Belial? or what part hath he that believeth with an infidel? And what agreement hath the temple of God with idols? for ye are the temple of the living God; as God hath said, I will dwell in them, and walk in them; and I will be their God, and they shall be my people*” (2 Corinthians 6:14–16) (see also Leviticus 26:12).

This is different from the Old Testament type of the Tabernacle in the wilderness and the Temple in Jerusalem. We are the temple of the living God, His fulfillment being His Holy Spirit in His people—the Comforter, the Holy Spirit, as promised by Christ (for context, please read John 14:1–23).

Continued in the next issue. ✝

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